idolatry that they persisted with the destruction for nearly a month.[5] The Taliban's leader, Mullah Omar, had passed a decree on 26 February 2001, ordering the elimination of all non-Islamic statues in Afghanistan. By the end of March, the Buddhas of Bamiyan had ceased to exist. Statues kept in the Afghan National Museum in Kabul were not spared either. The world erupted in rage. Countries with high numbers of Buddhists such as Sri Lanka, China, Japan, Laos, Myanmar, Bhutan, Cambodia, and Thailand protested heavily. Even Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE, who recognised and supported the Taliban, joined the protests. As Dixit put it, for India where Buddhism was born and 0.8 per cent of whose population still practiced it,[6] the Taliban's 'cup of evil doing' had begun to overflow.[7]

This was not the first time the Bamiyan Buddhas had come up in India's policy debates. BJP MP Vijay Kumar Malhotra had raised concerns over the Taliban's intent to destroy them since May 1997. Then PM Gujral, who was under some, if not considerable, influence of the conciliators, shared the concern but could do little about it.[8] Bamiyan was untouched by the civil war in 1997 and did not occupy strategic priority. The ghastly events of 2001, however, put both the partisans and the conciliators on the same page, as India activated its diplomatic channels to further isolate the Taliban internationally. On 2 March 2001, both houses of the parliament unanimously passed a resolution condemning the destruction as 'medieval barbarism' and 'sacrilege to humanity'.[9] Parliamentarians from both national and regional political parties cutting across the ideological spectrum denounced the Taliban.[10] When placing the resolution in the house, Jaswant Singh offered to arrange for the transfer of all these artifacts to India where they would be kept safely, 'in the full knowledge and clear understanding that they are, in the first place and above all, treasures of the Afghan people themselves'.[11]

Coming from a Hindu nationalist government, Jaswant Singh's statement was loaded with irony. The BJP and its ideological parent organisation, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), had allegedly incited a large crowd of Hindu *Kar Sevaks* (volunteers) to demolish the Babri Masjid (Mosque of Babur) in 1992 in the central Indian state of Uttar Pradesh (UP). Former Indian defence minister and Samajwadi Party leader Mulayam Singh, a senior regional politician from UP